

are around. The OFA runs the Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF) program, which has been up and running since 1997. Not only does the program provide free job training and education, but it helps with locating grants that pay for Child Care. By contacting state agencies, it can find a program that is right for you. You can learn more at www.acf.hhs.gov/programs/ofa/. Also, be sure to check out some other opportunities at www.childcareaware.org or www.workfamily.org.

The Child Care and Development Block Grant (CCDBG) provides funds to assist with Child Care costs as well. The U.S. Department of Health and Human Services is responsible for heading this terrific organization. Every year, financial burden is eased, as families receive up to thousands of dollars to pay their Child Care costs. Parents are allowed to choose their own Child Care provider, as long as it is legally operating and it meets all state health and safety requirements. More information can be found at www.naeyc.org/policy/federal/ccdbg.asp or www.nccic.org.

Does dread fill your chest when you hear the words *Internal Revenue Service*? When I tell you about the amazing Child Care benefits they offer, you might want to change your tune. Just take a look at their Publication 503, which is entitled *Child and Dependent Care Expenses*. You may be eligible to receive hundreds, even thousands, toward paying off Child Care. To learn more about this, go to www.irs.gov. You can also call them directly at: 1-800-829-1040.

There are many employers out there that offer a plan where you can pay your Child Care with pre-tax money – that means big savings at the end of the year. So don't waste any time in contacting your employer to find out if this benefit is available to you. Remember, you never know until you ask.

Aside from Child Care, raising a child brings about a number of other considerations. Education is a fundamental piece of the puzzle, and it's something that we should never skimp on. Head Start exists to provide your child with free Pre-School! Geared toward providing low-income families with the tools to successfully enhance the development of their children, the program offers a variety of educational, social, and health services. Armed with the skills to go into kindergarten with confidence, children get a "head start" on the path toward success. You